

Swanzey Financial & Governance Review

15 years of budgets, votes, and patterns — and where it's heading

Town of Swanzey, Cheshire County, New Hampshire

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1. Executive Summary

Across 15 years of official-ballot town meetings, Swanzey's electorate is consistent, legible, and increasingly stressed. Voters will fund operations but will not borrow; they reward saving and tax credits and punish bonds; their support for the operating budget is eroding; and they are actively restructuring how the town governs itself — all while the Town Administrator's office keeps turning over. The town is simultaneously taking on more (a water utility) and losing the executive continuity needed to deliver it.

Headline figures

\$5.75M → \$8.94M	operating budget, 2012 → 2026 (+55%)
≈ 6.7%/yr	recent growth (2022–2026)
81% → 57%	operating-budget voter support, 2011 → 2025
\$47K (0.5%)	2026 default-vs-proposed gap — the lever is weak
2024 & 2026	public works facility 3/5 votes — both failed
3	town administrators in ~2 years

The recommendation in one line

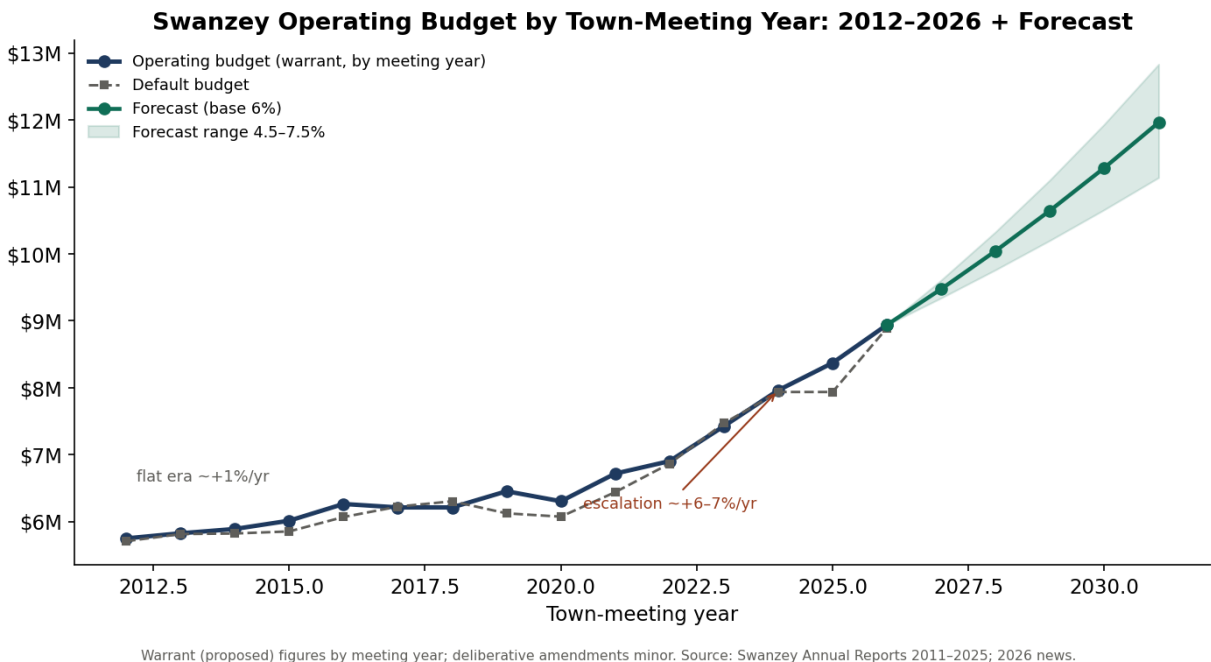
Stabilize the administrator, abandon bond-first capital for the reserve/state-aid/SRF strategy the electorate already rewards, and tell voters the truth about revaluation and the budget — in that order.

2. Findings

Provenance: [R-AR] Town of Swanzezy Annual Reports 2011–2025; [R-news] local news (2026); [D] derived; [M] modeled. Forecasts are scenarios.

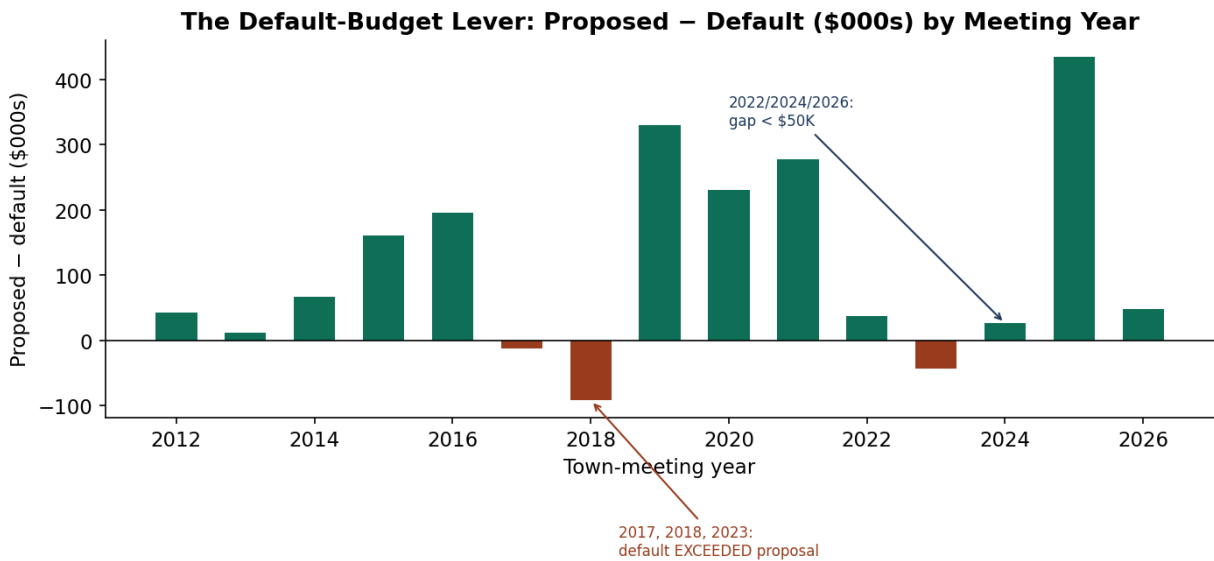
Finding 1 — Operating budget has entered a high-growth regime

After a flat early-2010s (~+1%/yr), the budget shifted to +6–7%/yr (2020–2026), rising 55% to \$8.94M (warrant figures by meeting year; amendments minor) — driven by wages, health insurance, and the ambulance contract.



Finding 2 — The default-budget lever has effectively disappeared

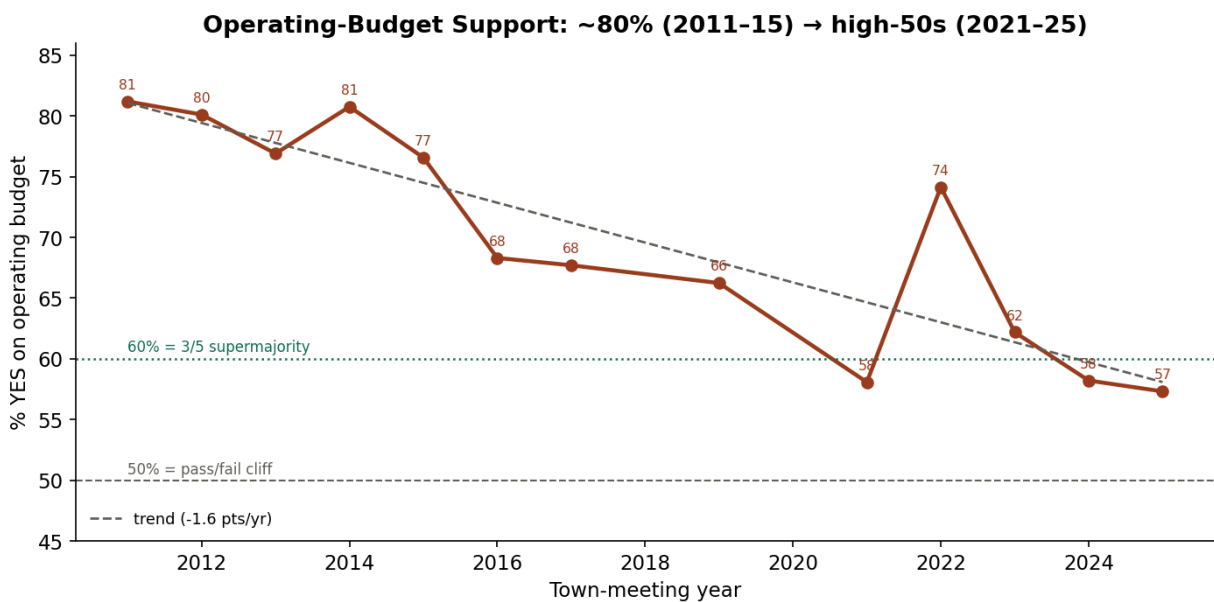
The default exceeded the proposal in 2017, 2018, and 2023, and came within ~\$50K in 2022, 2024, and 2026 (\$47K). 'Vote no to save money' largely doesn't work — the pressure valve is mostly closed.



A 'no' vote installs the default. Repeatedly near-zero or negative — the savings lever is weak. Source: Annual Reports.

Finding 3 — Operating-budget support is eroding toward the 50% cliff

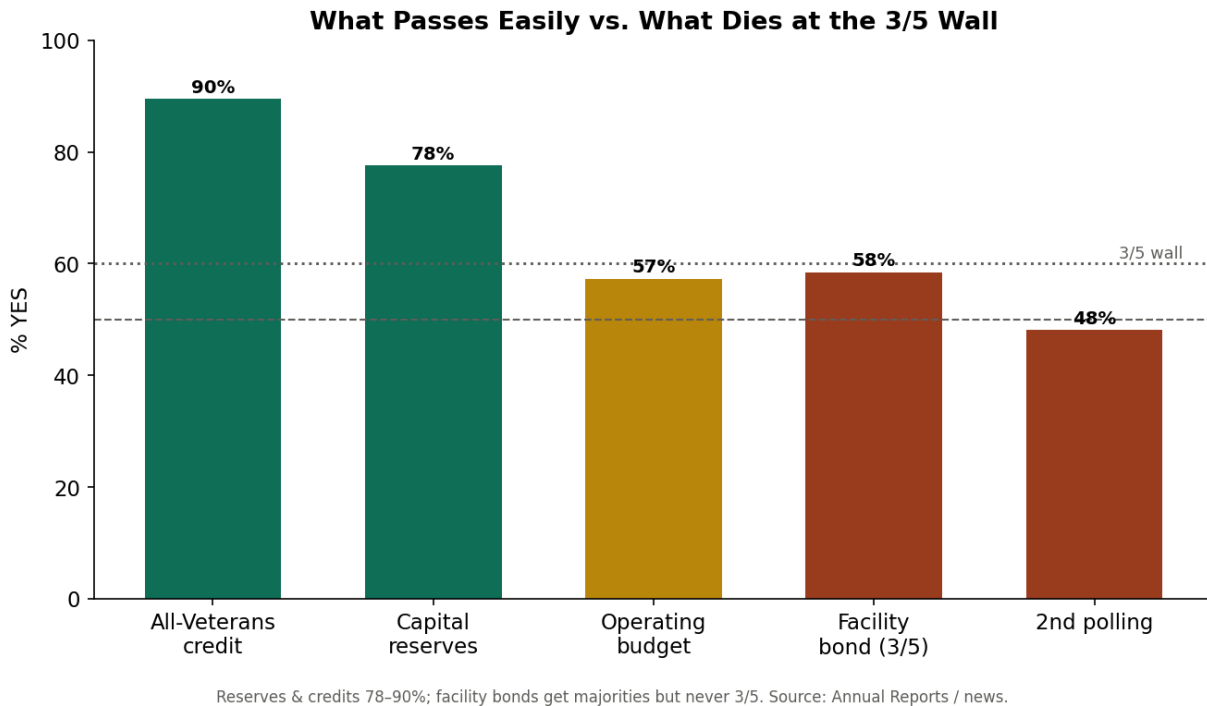
Approval fell from ~80% (2011–2015) to 57% (2025). A budget failure becomes plausible within a few cycles, though its fiscal impact would now be muted.



13 of 15 years (2018 & 2020 tallies not machine-readable). Source: Swanzev Annual Reports.

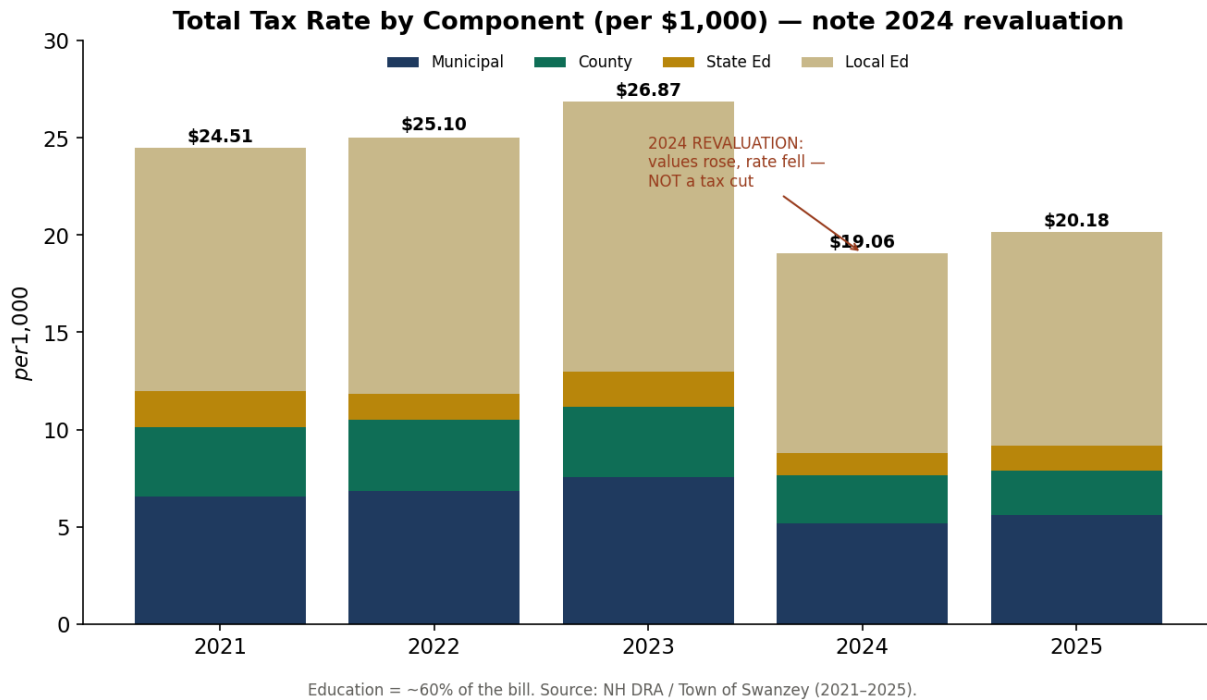
Finding 4 — Capital paralysis at the 3/5 wall

Tax credits pass ~90% and reserves ~78%, but facility bonds get 55–58% — never the 3/5 a bond needs. The public works facility failed at 3/5 in 2024 and 2026. A threshold problem, not an opposition problem.



Finding 5 — The 2024 rate decline was a revaluation, not a tax cut

Total rate moved \$26.87 (2023) → \$19.06 (2024) → \$20.18 (2025); the 2024 drop reflects higher assessed values, not lower bills. Education is ~60% of the bill.



Finding 6 — Governance is being actively restructured

Voters expanded the Select Board 3→5 (2025, 740–653), rejected a second polling location (673–727), and kept SB2 (rejected repeal 345–809 in 2026) — overruling a board that had recommended repeal.

Finding 7 — Administrative instability is the master pain

Three administrators in ~2 years (Branley → Torpey interim → Rautiola → open). Every other initiative restarts with each turnover.

Finding 8 — Development and land use are a live legal exposure

The Avanru 74-unit senior-housing project drew a federal lawsuit alleging boards relied on opposition rather than zoning criteria; the Base Hill Road storage facility has been a multi-year dispute.

Finding 9 — The town is absorbing a water utility

In 2025 voters authorized acquiring the West Swanzey water system (RSA 38:4), created a TIF district, appropriated \$3.5M and \$6.4M, and funded a study expecting '100% principal forgiveness' (NHDES DWSRF).

Finding 10 — Electoral volatility is rising

Crowded fields, sub-30-vote margins, ousted incumbents, and recounts. Continuity is the scarcest resource.

3. Recommendations

Sequenced for impact.

R1 — Stabilize the Town Administrator (first)

Churn is the precondition pain. Offer a multi-year agreement with a written evaluation and a board–administrator delegation policy. (RSA 41)

R2 — Reserve + state-aid + SRF capital

Bonds die at 3/5; reserves and aid pass. Stand up capital reserve funds (majority vote), pursue 80% bridge aid (RSA 234) and DWSRF water financing. (RSA 35)

R3 — Tell the truth on revaluation & the budget

Publish a plain-language tax-bill explainer and a budget-driver brief. (RSA 21-J, 76)

R4 — Publish a six-year CIP annually

Convert surprise capital into expected line items. (RSA 674:5–8)

R5 — Govern the new five-member board

Adopt operating norms and onboarding. (RSA 41:8, 91-A, 31:39-a)

R6 — Run water as an enterprise

Rate study + asset-management plan; DWSRF repaid by rates. (RSA 38)

R7 — De-risk land-use decisions

Decide strictly on written criteria, with counsel. (RSA 672–677)

Sequencing

R1 is the keystone. R2 and R4 unlock the capital backlog the electorate keeps blocking. R3 rebuilds the trust R2's votes require. R5–R7 protect the institution while the rest takes hold.

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